Ungrateful

By Linda Eisenstein

INTRODUCTION

"No ma, I don't want any green beans." (mimicking) "There are children starving in Africa that would love the chance to eat those beans."
Ungrateful.
"I've been standing all day and my legs are killing me!" (mimicking)"You know, some people don't even have legs to stand on."
Ungrateful.
"Can't you drive me? It's such a long walk." (mimicking) "Back in my day we had to walk five miles to school, uphill both ways!"
Ungrateful.
We're a bunch of ungrateful people living in an ungrateful time. Let's put things in perspective.
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MEG: SO there I am after the show, cooling my heels in the Playhouse Square* lobby *(Note: insert the name of your big-buck commercial theatre here: the one that would present the touring production of "Cats".)* for what seems like hours, because as usual Dana was late AGAIN! And I'm waiting, and waiting, and waiting for the damn car to show up, and there's no sight of Dana, of course, and I've called the apartment twice and gotten the answering machine twice, and I figure she's probably in some book store browsing around without a care in the world, or having a second cup of Cafe Latte blabbing away with somebody, losing track of time while I'm just standing here looking stupid. And so I think about maybe getting a cab, and I look in my wallet and discover I don't have enough money for one, and I'm getting more and more steamed, and more and more freaked out, until I can't even pay attention to the book I brought for this very purpose, because all I do is look up every ten seconds wishing the goddamn car and

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goddamn Dana would GET here, already, and soon all I'm doing is pacing up and down. Until now it finally IS a whole hour that I've been waiting, and they actually make me switch lobbies, and they're starting to run the big industrial-sized vacuum cleaner and there's nobody there but me and the security guard and he wants to go home. And the frustration is starting to turn into panic and I'm muttering to myself, on the verge of hysteria, swearing I'm going to kill Dana the moment the car pulls up, that is, if she's not already dead from a traffic accident. . .

And THEN it starts to rain. And I totally lose it, man, I'm standing there staring out the glass doors, wracking sobs are pouring out of me, I'm actually sobbing with rage and loss and the sense of abandonment, feeling like a total fucking orphan of the storm, okay? And you know what happens then? A homeless guy walks by. *(Pause.)* Outside. In the rain. A homeless guy walks by. And boom, two words light up my mind like a sudden flash of lightning, and I hear a voice. And it says: "Ungrateful girl."
It's my grandmother's voice. Not an angry voice, I don't ever remember her being angry. She'd just get this tone of regret, shaking her head, like you just didn't understand something. *(A sigh.)* "Ungrateful girl." And it's like a sword in my heart.

You know, I don't mean to be ungrateful. Really. I don't. It's not the way I was raised. "Be grateful for small favors." Grandma used to say stuff like that all the time. When you'd complain about some injury, like a teacher was nasty, or your feet hurt, she'd shrug and say" some people don't have any

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legs." Or, "people are starving in Armenia," she'd say, as she filled your plate with food you didn't want. Well, they're starving in Armenia again, Grandma. And in Bosnia, and Chechnya, and a bunch of other places I can barely pronounce, but they all sound like places my grandmother could have been from. I could be from there. I could be living in one of those places now, starving and ducking bombs, if my grandmother hadn't gotten the hell out. Gotten out when she was still an ungrateful girl herself. A servant girl, who refused to listen to some priest's sermon about her duty. A hungry servant girl, who stole meat from her master's dog.

I figure that must be why we're all so ungrateful, so restless here. America is bubbling over with the gene-pool of the people who wouldn't sit still. We're all the children and grandchildren and great grandchildren of the ones who refused to sit and take whatever was dished out. So we're all congenitally ungrateful, you and I. We sit in our houses surrounded by riches and privilege and every convenience and advantage, bitching and moaning our heads off. Ungrateful, ungrateful.

Some places we would be illegal. Things I do, things I take for granted every day, could get me thrown in jail somewhere else. Tortured. Even killed. Did you see the pictures of those Iranian women, the ones who wouldn't wear the veil? With the black sacks over their heads, right before the trapdoor sank under their feet? That could be me. Or you. And I'm still fucking ungrateful, and so are you, I can see it in your eyes. And why not? I don't think I should have to rejoice just because I'm not locked up. Why shouldn't

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freedom be the norm? Am I supposed to feel good because I only get dirty looks instead of a boot in the back or a truncheon to the head? Not hardly. Not hardly.

But it got to me, man. When I was standing there, watching that guy walk by in the rain. And I thought, maybe this life-this life in which I feel like I'm suffering so much, this life where I cry and cry-this one's the reward. It's time off for good behavior, man. Maybe in the last bunch of lives, they *really* got me burned me as a witch, or shot me and left me in a ditch with the other corpses, or left me starving in some rat-hole for the jailers to rape. This life? This one's the reward. The one where they don't gouge my eyes out. The one where all I get is the occasional sneer, and a stack of unpaid bills, and a lover that leaves me standing alone in the lobby for an hour after some fluffy Broadway touring show, where the ticket cost more than somebody's Third World paycheck.

Oh, Jesus. I'm supposed to be standing here feeling grateful. Grateful for only being marginalized and misunderstood and ignored now and then. Hey, that's a piece of cake, babe. That's ice cream and butterflies and a walk in the park. And then this car finally pulls up in the rain, fenders rattling-and there's Dana, with that look, you know, that guilty" I really screwed up, go ahead and walk on my face with your hobnailed boots" hunched-over LOOK-and all I could think of was-Oh, babe. Oh, babe. We don't know how lucky we are.

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